

Gauntlet v0.6.3 First Game Guide

Teaching order and tableside procedures - release candidate · Prepared August 11, 2026 · Not published

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1. First-game teaching order

Teach in three layers:

1. **The shared game** — the turn, Movement, one ordinary battle, Occupation, Capture, and running the Gauntlet.
2. **Your faction** — its resource or progression, Leader, Faction Actions and Abilities, and additional victory.
3. **The opponent's faction** — only the public information needed to make decisions against it.

Do not begin by reading both complete faction guides aloud. Each player receives one authoritative tableside faction reference for their own faction and one concise opponent summary for the opposing faction.

Before faction rules

Physically demonstrate:

1. one ordinary turn;
2. one ordinary battle with Hand, Gambit, Reserve, and Tactic visibly separated;
3. Fall Back, withdrawal, and retreat as three different movements;
4. an attacker becoming the occupier after winning;
5. Capture advancing the Front Line on a later turn; and
6. a bound card placed beneath the effect that binds it.

Only after this shared demonstration should each player learn their faction overlay.

2. Setup for v0.6.3

1. Prepare faction and Leader components that can add cards to or remove cards from the Deck.
2. Shuffle the remaining Deck to form the Draw Pile.
3. Draw four cards, discard one face up, and keep three as the opening Hand.
4. With that Hand and opening discard known, secretly arrange your three Territories.
5. Join and reveal both Territory lines to form the Gauntlet.
6. Place each Player Token on the Territory at that player's own end. This is not movement and does not count as entering.
7. Only after both players finish opening selection and Territory arrangement, roll for first player.

Running the Gauntlet

There are two normal victory routes: **capture the Territory at your opponent's end** or **win your opponent's Last Stand**. Either runs the Gauntlet and wins immediately. A separate legal movement sequence can initiate a Last Stand after the opponent is forced beyond their end; prior capture of the final Territory is not required.

3. Shared tableside turn reference

Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup

Capture

If the active player's token is on or beyond the next opposing Territory immediately beyond their Front Line, add that Territory to their Front Line.

- Control remains contiguous from the player's own end.
- Position may extend beyond control.
- Normal Capture advances the Front Line by at most one Territory.

Draw

Draw one card.

Opening

The active player may take their Action now.

Movement

Choose one:

- **Advance:** move one Position toward the opponent's end;
- **Hold:** remain in the current Position; or
- **Fall Back:** move one Position toward the active player's own end.

Entering the opponent's Position creates a pending battle and ends the current Movement sequence.

Denouement

The active player may take their Action now if they did not take it during Opening.

Cleanup

Resolve end-of-turn effects, discard down to the Hand limit, and pass the active-player marker.

Action reminder

A player normally takes one Action during either Opening or Denouement.

An Action may:

- play a card for its Action effect;
- bank a card from Hand using its inherent Bank Action if it has an Asset effect;
- take a legal Faction Action; or
- discard one of the player's Assets.

An additional Action does not by itself permit two Actions in one phase.

4. Shared tableside battle reference

Pending battle

Pending battle → Terms → Onset → Gambits

1. Establish attacker, defender, contested Position, and the attacker's previous Position.
2. Resolve Terms if a Diplomat is involved.
3. Accepted Terms prevent the battle.
4. Refused Terms or no Terms proceed to Onset.

Active battle

Onset → set Gambits → form Reserves → reveal Gambits → choose Tactics → reveal Tactics → Outcome → Aftermath

Onset

Resolve effects used during Onset before Gambits are set.

Before you commit cards to a battle, look beyond your Hand. Read the contested Territory and scan your Asset Bank. Those effects are easy to overlook once Gambits, Reserves, and Tactics begin, and some may matter at different points in the battle. Check when each effect can be used before you act.

Gambit

Each player may set one eligible card from Hand face down. The card is no longer in Hand while it is in battle.

Reserve

Each player normally draws three cards into a temporary private Reserve.

Tactic

Each player may normally choose one eligible card from Reserve. Cards left in Reserve remain separate from Hand.

Outcome

Apply active effects, roll, and compare battle totals.

- When the defender has **Defensive Edge**, the defender wins tied battle totals.
- If the tie remains unresolved, make a separate unmodified **Tiebreak Roll**.
- Higher Tiebreak Roll wins; reroll further ties.

Aftermath

Apply the result, retreat the loser, establish Occupation when applicable, resolve Aftermath effects, and clear battle cards to their normal destinations.

5. Movement and result diagram

Use this verbal and visual distinction on every player reference:

Fall Back is ordinary Movement. A losing player retreats. A player who leaves without losing withdraws.

Fall Back

- chosen during the active player's normal Movement;
- moves one Position toward that player's own end;
- does not involve a battle result.

Retreat

- follows a battle loss;
- creates a winner and loser;
- triggers win, loss, retreat, and Occupation consequences.

Withdrawal

- ends or prevents a pending or active battle without a winner;
- triggers no win, loss, or retreat effects;
- before Onset, produces no battle or Aftermath;
- after Onset, completes the remaining non-result Aftermath and clears committed cards normally.

Occupation and Capture

1. An attacker wins on an opposing controlled Territory.
 2. The defender retreats.
 3. The attacker remains and becomes the **occupier**.
 4. Control does not change yet.
 5. If the attacker remains on or beyond the next Territory beyond their Front Line until a later Capture step, that Territory joins the Front Line.
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6. Player-mat and zone specification

Each player mat must provide clearly separated labeled areas for:

- Draw Pile;
- Hand;
- Discard Pile;
- Graveyard;
- Asset Bank;
- Leader and faction components;
- Gambit;
- Reserve;
- Tactic;
- current Territory / Player Token relationship; and
- temporary bound cards.

The Hand remains the player's permanent private cards. Reserve is a separate temporary private zone used only during the current battle.

Battle-zone layout

Arrange battle zones in play order:

Hand → Gambit | Reserve → Tactic

The Gambit area should sit between the Hand and battle center. The Reserve and Tactic areas should be visibly separate so an unchosen Reserve card cannot be mistaken for a Tactic or Hand card.

Faction areas

- **Military:** Leader and Command tracker.
- **Diplomats:** Leader, Influence tracker, Proposal row, and ratified Treaty Articles.
- **Financiers:** Leader, Capital ledger, Treasury, and owned Deeds.
- **Intelligence:** Leader, Intel, Operation Progress, Active Mission or Special Operation.
- **Mystics:** Leader, three Rites, Ritual area, and bound-card spaces.
- **Inquisition:** Leader, Conviction tracker, doctrine, and Purge reference.

7. Bound-card diagram and reminder

A bound card is physically tucked beneath or placed immediately beside the effect that binds it, with enough of the card visible to identify it when public.

BOUND — outside Hand, Draw Pile, Discard Pile, Graveyard, Reserve, Tactic, and Asset Bank

- A face-up bound card is public.
- A face-down bound card may be inspected only by its owner.
- It cannot be played, moved, or affected except by the effect to which it is bound.
- The binding effect determines where it goes when the binding ends.

For Mystics Rites and the Ritual, the mat should show dedicated slots beneath the relevant Rite or Ritual reference. For Extraordinary Rendition, place the selected opposing card face up beneath the Asset.

8. Active-player marker

The active-player marker is a shared physical object passed after Cleanup.

Required face text

YOUR TURN

Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup

Required reminder text

- Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.
- Pass this marker after Cleanup.

The marker tracks only whose turn it is and the shared turn sequence. It does not track battle initiative, priority, Actions remaining, or the attacker.

Its final illustration, shape, stock, and production form remain open for the release-production pass.

9. Faction teaching cards

Each faction reference uses the same order:

1. aim;

2. resource or progression;
3. Faction Actions;
4. Faction Abilities and public timing windows;
5. additional victory;
6. Leader comparison;
7. recommended starter Deck;
8. first-turn plan; and
9. opponent summary.

Military

Your faction

- **Aim:** Win battles, gain Command, and convert momentum into movement and control.
- **Resource:** Command, maximum 2. Gain 1 the first time each turn Military wins a battle.
- **Faction Actions:** None.
- **Faction Abilities:** Orders at their printed timings.
- **Additional victory:** None; Military runs the Gauntlet.
- **General:** Attacks repeatedly and carries momentum forward.
- **Commandant:** Defends controlled ground and turns defensive wins into pressure.
- **Recommended first Leader:** General.
- **Starter Decks:** Forward Doctrine / Holdfast.

Opponent summary

Track Command. Military may add movement, modify a battle, push a retreat farther, or advance its Front Line after a win. Invasion can enlarge an attacking Reserve and Tactic limit, but unused Invasion movement ends when a pending battle is created.

Diplomats

Your faction

- **Aim:** Offer Terms, ratify different Proposals, and reshape battles through agreement or refusal.
- **Resource:** Influence, 0–10; begin with 1.
- **Faction Actions:** None.
- **Faction procedure:** Offer Terms during a pending battle before Onset.
- **Faction Ability:** Leverage after refused Terms before dice.
- **Additional victory:** Peace Treaty after five different Proposals are ratified.
- **Ambassador:** Gains card flow from accepted Terms.
- **Senator:** Risks larger Stakes and preserves Influence after setbacks.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Ambassador.
- **Starter Decks:** Open Channels / Procedure Endures.

Opponent summary

Read the Proposal before accepting or refusing. Accepted Terms prevent the battle; refusal proceeds to Onset. The Diplomat gains more Influence by imposing a newly ratified Proposal after a win, and Détente rewards acceptance only when the Proposal was already ratified when offered.

Financiers

Your faction

- **Aim:** Build Capital and Treasury value, buy Deeds, and combine ownership with territorial pressure.
- **Resource:** Capital; begin with 2.

- **Faction Actions:** Treasury, Deed purchase, Play the Market, and Hostile Takeover during Denouement.
- **Faction Ability:** Subsidize before dice; Financial Capacity may permit an Action in both Opening and Denouement.
- **Additional victory:** Own the Deeds to every Territory through Controlling Interest.
- **Banker:** Uses cards as controlled collateral for purchases.
- **Executive:** Converts offensive Occupation into Deed ownership and Front Line control.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Executive.
- **Starter Decks:** Sound Investment / Hostile Expansion.

Opponent summary

Capital, Treasury, and Deeds are public. Financial Capacity may give the Financier both Action phases, provided one Action is a Financier Faction Action. Deed ownership does not itself equal Territory control.

Intelligence

Your faction

- **Aim:** Complete Missions, gain Intel and Operation Progress, and prepare a Special Operation.
- **Resources:** Intel and Operation Progress.
- **Faction Actions:** Start, complete, or abort a Mission; start or complete a Special Operation, all during Denouement.
- **Faction Abilities:** Surveillance, Interference, Fieldcraft, and Mission Control at their stated timings.
- **Additional victory:** Complete a ready Special Operation.
- **Ranger:** Uses Fieldcraft and terrain knowledge for flexible operations.
- **Spymaster:** Chains Missions through Mission Control.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Ranger.
- **Starter Decks:** Field Operations / Mission Network.

Opponent summary

Mission identity is hidden, but Intel and Operation Progress are public. Intelligence may reveal and interfere with a face-down Gambit and later with face-down Tactics. Replacements do not create a new information window.

Mystics

Your faction

- **Aim:** Complete three Rites, unlock Invocation, Transmutation, and Convergence, then complete the Ritual of Ascendance.
- **Progression:** Three public Rites; no resource tracker.
- **Faction Actions:** Begin a Rite or begin the Ritual during Denouement, except Nature's Altar may permit Begin a Rite during Opening.
- **Faction Abilities:** Rite completion, Invocation, Transmutation, Convergence, and Leader abilities.
- **Additional victory:** Initiate and win a battle while the three Ritual cards remain bound.
- **Alchemist:** Replaces deliberate sacrifice with card flow.
- **Spirit Walker:** Protects Rite and Ritual progress after a loss.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Spirit Walker.
- **Starter Decks:** First Principles / Unbroken Circle.

Opponent summary

Completed Rites and bound cards are public when face up. The Spirit Walker may prevent interruption by sacrificing an Arcane card with value 1, 2, 3, or 4 according to progress. Nature's Altar requires token presence to begin and control at completion timing for its same-turn exception.

Inquisition

Your faction

- **Aim:** Build Conviction, move opposing cards permanently into the Graveyard, and use Purge to remove options.
- **Resource:** Conviction, maximum 4.
- **Faction Action:** Purge during Opening or Denouement. A Purge Action permits one Action in each phase, provided one is Purge.
- **Faction Abilities:** Condemnation, Blasphemy, Final Judgment, and Relentless Pursuit.
- **Additional victory:** Purification when the opponent cannot make the normal start-of-turn draw because both Draw Pile and Discard Pile are empty.
- **Grand Inquisitor:** Converts battle wins into discounted Purges.
- **Witch Hunter:** Punishes failed attacks with immediate pursuit.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Grand Inquisitor.
- **Starter Decks:** Final Judgment / Relentless Pursuit.

Opponent summary

Opposing Tactics normally go to the Graveyard in battles against Inquisition. Track Conviction before playing Arcane cards or attacking the Witch Hunter. Martyrdom does not prevent a loss, but it can send cards remaining in the winner's Reserve to the Graveyard.

10. Introductory pairings

Preferred first pairing

Military — General vs Inquisition — Grand Inquisitor

Why:

- both players use the shared battle game directly;
- both resources are public and capped;
- neither player must learn hidden objectives or negotiation procedure first;
- each Leader demonstrates a clear win-to-resource loop; and
- the matchup teaches Graveyard consequences without requiring a second board subsystem.

Alternative first pairings

- **Military — Commandant vs Financiers — Executive:** defense and Occupation against direct acquisition.
- **Diplomats — Ambassador vs Military — General:** introduces Terms against an otherwise direct opponent.
- **Intelligence — Ranger vs Inquisition — Grand Inquisitor:** introduces hidden information while keeping the opposing faction public.

Pairings to reserve for a guided host

- Intelligence vs Mystics;
- Diplomats vs Intelligence;
- Financiers mirror;
- Diplomats mirror; and
- any pairing where both players are simultaneously learning hidden objectives, extensive interrupts, or alternate-victory sequencing.

These are teaching recommendations, not balance judgments or restrictions.

11. Five-minute guided first battle

Before beginning the actual game:

1. Place both Player Tokens together on a sample contested Territory.
2. Name an attacker and defender.
3. Skip Terms unless demonstrating Diplomats.
4. Announce **Onset**.
5. Each player takes any one card from the top of their Deck and places it face down as a sample Gambit.
6. Each player takes three more cards as a sample Reserve.
7. Each chooses one sample Tactic.
8. Reveal the sample Gambits and Tactics without applying printed effects.
9. Roll and identify whether Defensive Edge or a Tiebreak Roll would apply.
10. Demonstrate the loser's retreat, the attacker's Occupation when applicable, and the normal card destinations.
11. Return all demonstration cards, shuffle both Decks, reset the tokens, and begin normal setup draws.

This dry run teaches physical zones and result movement without altering the actual game or requiring players to understand four unfamiliar card effects at once.

12. Starter Deck presentation

For each recommended first-game Deck, present:

- Deck name;
- Leader and faction;
- one-sentence plan;
- Opening plan;
- four signature cards;
- Territory order from the player's own end outward;
- first-game tip;
- opponent watch text; and
- exact 30-card list and 60-value total.

Do not describe the starter as a reduced card pool. It is a coherent recommended Deck built from the full legal pool.

The v0.6.3 development Deckbuilder and `/v0.6.3/start/` flow use the v0.6.3 candidate data and adapted starter catalog.

13. Authority and release boundary

For the v0.6.3 release candidate:

1. The v0.6.3 Rulebook candidate and specific component text govern candidate play and review.
2. `Gauntlet_v0.6.3_Starter_Decks.json` governs the twelve recommended starter compositions in the assembled source candidate.
3. This document governs v0.6.3 first-game and tableside candidate presentation.
4. v0.6.2 remains the immutable published playtest release until the publication cutover is completed.

Later layout work may change typography, iconography, dimensions, and illustration, but it may not change the sequences, terminology, faction summaries, or starter compositions without a recorded superseding decision.